

Distracted gaze: Problematic use of mobile technologies in vacation contexts

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Highlights

- Draws attention to the implications when the tourist 'gaze' is distracted by ubiquitous connectivity.
- Highlights the various forms of distractions in the holiday context resulting from multitasking with mobile devices.
- Explores linkages between the problematic use of mobile media devices and leisure vacation outcomes.
- Challenges aspects of the predominant view on technology usage in tourism-related contexts.

Abstract

Digital technology has undeniably altered the way tourists experience destinations. Yet, the problematic use of smartphones and similar mobile devices in vacation contexts has received limited attention. Using descriptive and interpretive approaches, this study explores tourists' experiences and perspectives on the impact or lack thereof of continual engagement with mobile media devices on their tourism experiences. The broad-spectrum view was that mobile distraction takes "something" away from individual tourist experiences as well as travel groups' experiences, although interpretations of the significance of this forfeiture varied considerably. Findings highlight the perceived repercussions of various forms of digital distractions for the quality and scope of the tourist's consumption of sights and sounds; the tourist's wellbeing; social interactions; and the experiences of 'others'. However, some tourists' cognizance of these deleterious effects may not necessarily translate into mindful use of mobile technologies in the holiday context. Findings hold key implications for theory and practice.

Keywords: Digital distraction; Social media; Multitasking; Smartphones; Tourism; Divided attention; Technology paradoxes

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1. Introduction

The rising importance of mobile media devices (MMDs) in the 21st Century cannot be ignored. Smartphones, tablet computers, and wearable devices such as smartwatches are deeply transforming the way we engage with technology on daily basis. The International Telecoms Union (ITU, 2015) reports that mobile-cellular subscriptions worldwide has grown from 738 million in 2000 to over 7 billion in 2015, representing a penetration rate of 97%. Mobile broadband subscription penetration experienced the most dynamic growth within the last eight years by increasing 12 times to reach 47% in 2015 (ITU, 2015). Smartphones in particular have become a critical part of our daily lives. By 2013, global sales of smartphones had already crossed the one billion threshold and exceeded the sales of conventional phones.

This growing use of MMDs is in part due to their convenience (Wang, Park, & Fesenmaier, 2012) and multifunctional applications (Kennedy-Eden & Gretzel, 2012). An increasing number of people are employing smartphones for tasks that were hitherto only available on personal computers. This has further created a perceived need to always stay 'wired' to multiple media devices (Courage, Bakhtiar, Fitzpatrick, Kenny, & Brandeau, 2015). The 2016 Global Mobile Consumer Survey reveals that 93% of smartphone owners check their phones within 3 h of waking up. Among younger users, this number extends to as much as 97%. The average person across all age groups in the US, for instance, looks at his or her phone 47 times per day (Deloitte, 2016).

There is no doubt that advances in web-enabled and multifunction mobile media devices have served to enhance the travel experience (Tussyadiah, 2015; Tussyadiah & Wang, 2016; Wang et al., 2012). The utility of MMDs for staying in touch with family, friends, and workplaces while away from home, for safeguarding safety, making enquiries, and obtaining directions,

as well as the convenience that comes from empowering travellers to be able to continue to amend travel plans after leaving home makes this technology invaluable for the leisure travel context (Ayeh, 2017a). Nonetheless, this has altered patterns of behaviour, making mobile technology pervasive and vulnerable to problematic use. Such problematic usage raises concern as it interferes with various activities in life (Augner & Hacker, 2012), not excluding those pursuits in the domain of travel and tourism (Wang, Xiang, & Fesenmaier, 2016). Continual engagement with MMDs, coupled with the habit of simultaneously processing multiple channels of information – termed multitasking – are emblematic of this pattern of usage. In tourism related contexts, the increased demand put on information processing resources in a holiday context by multitasking raises concern about the quality of the tourist experience (Ayeh, 2017b). Yet this has not been given the requisite attention in existing literature. This study therefore explores tourists' cognizance of the impacts or lack thereof of multitasking with MMDs on the touristic experience and their awareness of the possible implications.

‘When we ‘go away’, Urry and Larsen (2011) opine, ‘we look at the environment with interest and curiosity ... In other words, we gaze at what we encounter’ (p. 1). Though Urry and Larsen's (2011) “gaze” does not merely refer to the natural eye's vision but ‘the “discursive determinants” of socially constructed seeing or “scopic regimes”’ (p. 2), they nonetheless emphasise that this gaze is fixed on features of landscapes and townscapes which distinguish them from daily experience. In other words, what tourists *see around them* determine their experience; therefore, ‘What happens when this “gaze” is distracted?’ is a critical question that should not be ignored by the research community.

2. Literature review

2.1. The dark side of mobile technology use

The negative side of mobile technologies has drawn interest from scholars in various disciplines (e.g., Lee et al., 2014, Soror et al., 2015; Thomée, Härenstam, & Hagberg, 2011). Research has found use behaviours to have led to numerous unintended adverse consequences, such as stress (Thomée et al., 2011), sleep deprivation (Cain & Gradisar, 2010; Van den Bulck, 2003) and poorer learning (Chen & Yan, 2016; Fox, Rosen, & Crawford, 2008). Others have found the problematic use of cell phones as responsible for risky and illegal actions (Pennay, 2006) leading to increased vehicular accidents (National Safety Council, 2010), fatal injuries (Lamba et al., 2016, Mohn, 2017) and more teen deaths than drunk-driving (Techlicious, 2013).

Tourism research on mobile technologies however tends to applaud the invaluable role of these technologies in enhancing tourist experiences (e.g., Tussyadiah, 2015; Wang et al., 2012; Wang et al., 2016; White & White, 2007). A study by Wang et al. (2012) underscores how smartphones can alter tourists' behaviours and feelings by addressing a wide variety of information needs. Scholars have also recognised spill-over effects from smartphone usage in everyday life into travel (Wang et al., 2016). Still, these spill-over effects have been viewed largely from an optimistic perspective by emphasising outcomes such as confidence, safety, connection, flexibility, fun, and convenience.

Although the dark side of mobile technology is yet to be given deserving attention in extant tourism literature, recently, some scholars have recognised a paradox in technology usage in travel contexts (e.g., Pearce, 2011; Tribe & Mkono, 2017). In his book, *Tourist Behaviour and the Contemporary World*, Pearce (2011) describes how digital elasticity is displacing the

concept of liminality. Pierce elucidates how mobile technology mitigates cultural shock while at the same time diminishes the travel experience (Yang, 2013). From a series of focus group discussions, Pearce and Gretzel (2012) also observed that tourists' dependence on mobile connectivity results in several 'tensions' when they travel to destinations where Internet connectivity is unavailable. However, what remains unclear is the nature of the deficits incurred in the travel experience when tourists are continually engaged with mobile technologies in the holiday context. A recent study by Kirillova and Wang (2016) suggest that frequent use of smartphones for work-related communications tends to compromise a sense of recovery delivered by a travel destination, thus accentuating the need to further explore the implications of tourists' ubiquitous connectedness to MMDs for the tourism experience.

Most concerns about the undesirable consequences of mobile technology use, in the general literature, revolve around multitasking. Though there is pluralism in perspectives on the nature of the limitation in human information processing during dual-task performance, there appears to be a consensus that when two or more tasks are carried out synchronously, the cognitive system is constrained (Courage et al., 2015; Fox et al., 2008; Kemker, Stierwalt, LaPointe, & Heald, 2009). Psychology scholars assert that attention is a finite mental resource driving every cognitive activity (e.g., Pashler, 1994; Ruff & Rothbart, 2001). Contingent upon the demands of the activity, attentional resources can be dedicated to a single task or feature or divided more widely across numerous tasks or features (Courage et al., 2015). In the holiday context, this is more likely the case when a tourist carries out several tasks concurrently (e.g., chatting on a mobile app like WhatsApp, Facebook, etc. while listening to a tour guide; or taking photos/videos during a walking tour).

3. Research design and methodology

To probe respondents' reflections on their mobile phone usage behaviour in holiday contexts, naturalistic inquiry using focus groups and in-depth interviews was employed in the collection of primary data. The qualitative approach of this study was informed by Schutz's (1967) theory of social phenomenology as a philosophical lens as well as a methodological approach. As a descriptive and interpretive theory of social action, Schutz's social phenomenology explores subjective experience within the meaningful world of everyday life of individuals or what Schutz and Luckmann (1973) termed as the 'life-world'. The spatial and temporal aspects of experience and social relationships are considered highlights of this theory (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006). Social phenomenology assumes that individuals dwelling in the world of everyday life have the capability to assign meanings to situations and make judgments, often using conversations to discover the means employed by people for the sustenance of social relations (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006). In this study, the subjective meaning of experience was the primary issue for interpretation.

3.1. Data collection

Focus group discussions (FGDs) were first conducted with a convenient sample of three separate groups of young American tourists travelling overseas. The object of the focus groups was to generate a rudimentary understanding of the issues. In-depth interviews were subsequently conducted with another set of participants from more diverse backgrounds to further explore potential variations in the salient issues emerging from the FGDs.

A total of forty-two participants were recruited for the study. Data were collected via three focus groups and 22 individual interviews. Appendix A summarises respondents' background information. All the FGD participants were identified as moderate to frequent users of mobile

media devices, with ages ranging from 18 to 21 years. This sample falls within the segment of population (18–24) who most frequently check their mobile phones (a daily average of 82 times; Deloitte, 2016) and most likely to multitask with MMDs. Beastall (2008) describes this generation as having an advanced relationship with technology that is fashioned from birth. Representativeness was not a requirement since the focus was a proof of principle rather than population generalisation.

The discussions were guided by a series of open-ended questions that followed the principles of phenomenological psychology (Thompson, 1997) and sought to probe participants to reflect on their MMD use behaviour and its implications for the touristic experience and vacation outcomes (e.g., 'Tell me about your use of the smartphone when engaged with a tourist activity'). A wide range of issues were canvassed during this process. Based on respondents' own words, the study prodded for description and elaboration. The questions became increasingly more specific as the discussions progressed. Although the dialogues also explored participants' general use of mobile media devices for tourist-related endeavours, 'multitasking' and 'mobile distraction' were primary foci and often recurred at a number of points throughout the discussions. All the FGDs followed the same protocol to ensure consistency of approach.

Regarding the in-depth interviews, participants' ages ranged from 21 to 57 years old. In order to ensure broader representation, a judgmental sampling technique was used, and participants were purposively chosen to include a wide range of age and nationality backgrounds. The interviews were conducted from April to June 2016 and from September to October 2017. In the process of data collection and analysis, an interpretative framework was constructed; hence, the sampling strategy altered from mostly judgmental to largely theoretical to build on the evolving concepts. Novel aspects, categories, or explanations ceased emerging after about

12 sessions, and a satisfactory interpretative framework was constructed after 15 sessions: the point of thematic and theoretical saturation (Marshall, 1996). Nonetheless, the interviews recontinued till the 22nd session, allowing for supplementary validation of the interpretive framework. Saturation is attained when responses tend to be repetitive with no new points or issues developing, thus gesticulating the adequacy of the data collected. Interviewees comprised of ten different nationalities, namely: Americans, Portuguese, Kenyans, Emiratis, Taiwanese, Ugandan, South African, Canadian, Indian and an Australian (Appendix A). The interviews lasted from 26 min to 80 min and the discussions were audio-recorded and subsequently transcribed with the help of two research aides. The contents were then analysed to separate all data of relevance to the study purpose.

3.2. Data analysis

To Schutz, ensuring the subjective perspective is of prime importance if the life-world (or world of social reality) is not to be substituted by 'a fictional, non-existent world constructed by the researcher' (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006, p. 81). For this purpose, Schutz (1967) proposes a method for studying social action involving two orders of *verstehen* (empathic or participatory understanding of human behaviour). The first order of understanding connotes the process by which daily world phenomena is interpreted by individuals. The second order involves the formulation of 'ideal types' as lenses through which to interpret and depict the phenomenon under investigation. Following Fereday and Muir-Cochrane's (2006) hybrid approach to thematic analysis, this study employed the data-driven inductive approach (Caudle, 2004; Miles & Huberman, 1994) as well as the deductive a priori template of the codes approach recommended by Crabtree and Miller (1999) to meet the second level of interpretive understanding. The prime merit of this approach is that it permits the integration of social phenomenology tenets into the process of deductive thematic analysis in addition to

creating room for themes to emerge directly from the data by means of inductive coding (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006).

First, the audio-recorded data were listened to in order to become familiarised with the data before transcribing. In analysing the transcribed data, the study applied a content analysis technique comparable to the one described by Miles and Huberman (1994). Starting with opening coding, emergent codes were developed from the data using the posteriori approach. Following the approach suggested by Strauss (1987), relationships between open codes were sought (axial coding), and some codes were subsequently examined over and above others (selective coding) (Miles & Huberman, 1994). Initially, descriptive codes were developed to label each section of the transcript. Following the development of the descriptive codes, interpretive codes aided the drawing of conclusions from the analysis. Lastly, pattern codes were developed to help identify themes and relationships in the data. The process was iterative, allowing for the continual review and amendment of salient issues, lines of enquiry and relevant literature. Also, the approach offered opportunities for follow-up on insights before ending the data collection process. Considerable efforts were put in place to ensure appropriate interpretations and the drawing of objective analytic conclusions from the meaningful and symbolic content of the data. To ensure the trustworthiness of the data, the three essential postulates of Schutz's (1973) – logical consistency, subjective interpretation, and adequacy – were observed throughout the research process.

4. Findings and discussion

4.1. Tourists and multitasking

Generally, participants recognised the act of multitasking with mobile media devices as an increasingly popular phenomenon. All participants for the FGDs and most of the interviewees

admitted to having multitasked with their mobile media devices when engaged in a tourist activity, with some stressing doing so on very regular basis. When multitasking in the holiday context, respondents were likely to be doing several things on their mobile media devices: instant messaging; sending and checking emails; monitoring friends' updates or updating their own profiles on social networks; microblogging on Twitter; or playing games and taking real-time photos and videos and uploading on social media sites. Others employed their MMDs to search for on-site information about the tourist sites being visited. The responses underscored the resourcefulness of MMDs in the holiday domain (Kennedy-Eden & Gretzel, 2012). This versatility of MMDs in the holiday context was well expressed by a participant as:

Now I find I can't separate myself from it [smartphone] because I use it for a lot of different purposes. I use my mobile to communicate. I use it, especially when I travel, to allow people to know where I am—just in case something happens. I use it for photo taking. I use it as a note taker so I don't have to pull a pencil or paper out of my handbag. I can jot it down on my tablet or phone—usually my smartphone. [IDI-5].

Participants also acknowledged the enhancement that the MMD use brings to the travel experience. One interviewee [IDI-8] stressed: 'For me, I feel it enriches my experience—I can share with others, I can talk about it...' While some respondents rationalised their multitasking behaviour in the holiday context with the versatility of smartphones and the enrichment it offers to the travel experience, others suggested that this behaviour was more reflexive than rational. Responses like 'It's kind of awkward because even when we are outside enjoying a new place, I still have to have my mobile and be looking at it... you can get everything but I still use the mobile' [IDI-8] was re-echoed in diverse ways. Others recognised this behaviour as spontaneous, noting that tour group members often do not realize when they are multitasking with the use of smart devices: 'We are so used to having it

within reach that sometimes it doesn't even register that you actually ... until someone says: hey, I'm talking to you!' [IDI-13].

4.2. Tourists' cognizance of the deleterious effects of multitasking on travel experience

Despite participants' addictive dependencies on MMDs, when probed to reflect on the personal outcomes of multitasking in leisure vacation contexts, the term “distraction” was a recurring theme. The broad-spectrum view was that mobile distraction takes ‘something’ away from individual tourist experiences as well as travel groups' experiences, although interpretations of the significance of this forfeiture varied considerably among participants.

Participants recognised that this practice undermines various aspects of their travelling experiences, making them fail to observe certain sights and sounds on the tourist trail. One respondent [FGD-3] was quick to liken this *distracting* experience to sitting in a lecture hall and multitasking when there is an ongoing lecture: ‘You miss a great deal!’ she exclaimed. Another [FGD-9] observed that multitasking ‘...detracts from the experience of being there’. Recalling her experience in a Canadian National Park which had Internet access points, a participant [FGD-10] emphasised what she lost from that experience in contrast to her trip to a national park in Ghana that had no Internet access: ‘If I travel and have unlimited [Internet] access... I am unable to appreciate nature because I am always on the phone’. Another observed, ‘If I have no access to family and friends [online], I will be forced to explore the area, know other people, learn more...’ [FGD-13].

Shared experiences from respondents reveal that the resultant distraction may occur via various modes: (a) *visual* (e.g., eyes off the scenery while fixated on the screen), (b) *auditory* (e.g., not paying attention to tour guide or travel companion while absorbed in a call or an

online conversation), (c) *manual* (e.g., fidgeting with mobile device rather than resting or engaging in some tourist activities), (d) *emotional* (e.g., disruption to tourist mood by a message delivered via MMDs, often leading to emotional arousals such as anger, sadness, irritation, fear, or excitement and pulling sentiments away from the 'present' tourist environment) or (e) *cognitive* (e.g., being absent-minded due to a message read on the smartphone device).

These distractions often challenge (i) *the quality and scope of the travel experience* through inattentional (or perceptual) blindness (Mack & Rock, 1998; Simons & Chabris, 1999), time loss, and the mediated nature of the experience, among others. Responses from both the FGDs and in-depth interviews appear to mirror participants' recognition of the deficits incurred from the distribution of attentional resources in holiday contexts. As one commented:

You are kind of missing what's happening around you. Your attention is somewhere and you are missing something else. If your attention is on the device, then you are missing what is happening around you. If you are focusing on the camera you're missing a lot too. I think people are missing on real ... experiences. [IDI-9].

Research from cognitive psychology has indicated that human information processing is undeniably a limited capacity system, and when attention is shared or switched among different tasks, dual-task interference or switch cost is observed in slower reaction time, increased mistakes, and prolonged task completion time (see, Courage et al., 2015).

Besides, some travellers emphasised the mediated nature of the tourist experience as inherently problematic. An interviewee described this as follows:

When you focus on the screen, you are not experiencing—you are not interacting ... Really, I feel—in my own opinion—you completely forget why you are here! If it is about photo taking, you can Photoshop—you don't even need to come. You could edit and put yourself there in the photo. [IDI-1].

Several participants reiterated how mobile distraction steals time away from the 'real' experience. The time lost to this habit limits their ability to accomplish travel-related goals. A traveller [IDI-6] remarked: 'When we play on our phones, we don't even get to create the memories of the moment because you are doing something else—it wastes the time!' In appraising her travel experience in Panama, an interviewee observed:

I was lying at the beach; three-quarters of the time, I was on my phone. What I paid for was to sit on a beach and enjoy the view but I was looking at my phone—so, there were times when I couldn't look or do what I was supposed to be doing. The only thing I find with the phone ... is it robs you of time! [IDI-12].

Other travellers accentuated the financial implications of engaging in this behaviour in holiday contexts. In their view, it does not result in fair value for the money expended on the experience. One observed:

In the travel group that I am part of, people are free to act as they wish. I don't want to be judgmental, but I have seen it to the extreme. Someone will be killing the time ... checking Facebook or something like that. It seems like a habitual behaviour. It just seems like a kind of *waste* to spend money to go on vacation but then stay totally connected to the apps on your phone as opposed to being present on your vacation. [IDI-9].

This perspective was not only typical of responses from the older generation of travellers but also from some young ones. For instance, one reasoned:

You might not get your money's worth! You went to the trip so that you could benefit but you are not benefiting from what you've paid for ... for the tours we took in the US, you had to pay for it. We went to a private museum, so you have to pay for it. You are wasting time as well ... that is a sad thing. [IDI-3].

Some respondents considered the use of MMDs and associated gadgets by “other” travellers in their tour group as a disturbance to their *own* travel experiences. Others found it sardonic. One participant sarcastically remarked:

Tourists taking photos with their iPads. It's ridiculous! It's so big! That's what I think about when I think of tourists and technology. It is really ... oh and then the selfies! Selfies and the sticks!! That's a big thing! That's what I think about when I think of tourists and cell phones. ...People around the camera phones, plugged in with their earphones and iPads! [IDI-12].

The (ii) *wellbeing* of tourists was as well captured in the implications of use behaviour. Responses suggest potential corollaries for tourists' mental states and anxieties, psychological fatigue, sense of recovery, stress, and other tensions. One participant echoed this when she observed:

I know the phone takes away a lot of personal time and makes you stressed out. I think in general most technologies do ... so if you travel and have your phone with you, you bring some of the stress with you, because that phone is also what connects you to the stress point ... like if you are having e-mail that you received ... may stress you out. [IDI-3].

Tourism has long been recognised for its value in restoring psychological wellbeing: over half a century ago, Hills (1965) opined that a holiday is taken in response to a sense of ‘damage or depletion’ and therefore symbolises a period of replenishment and restoration. The restorative qualities of vacation destinations have further been underscored in more

recent studies (e.g., Lehto, 2013; Pyke, Hartwell, Blake, & Hemingway, 2016). Nonetheless, some travellers recognised that continual engagement with MMDs could equipose this value. Recent accidents (including fatal incidents) arising from selfie activities (see, Lamba et al., 2016; Mohn, 2017) demonstrate that the problematic use of mobile media devices in the vacation context could harm, not only tourists' mental and emotional wellbeing, but also, their physical wellbeing.

(iii) *Social interactions* during travel is another key category that emerged. Participants related their experiences on how frequent engagement with MMDs led to less connection with tour group members and other players encountered on the tourist trail. One group (FGD) emphasised that there was stronger 'bonding' among them as a tour group whenever they found themselves in regions where there was no Internet access or places that would fit Pearce and Gretzel's (2012) description of 'technology dead zones'. Others acknowledged the importance of such travel destination contexts as resulting in '... more conversations' [FGD-16] and improved relationships with travel party members: '... we've been able to create friendships devoid of Facebook, Twitter, and others', one [FGD-4] remarked.

Paris (2010) narrates a similar concern by a backpacker:

I've sat in hostel common rooms where 10 backpackers were silently staring at screens, gathering information about the city they are in on Twitter rather than talking to each other, meeting new friends, and sharing information through the 'traveller network' that is right in the room (p. 115).

Some concerns raised have to do with (iv) 'relationships' in the vacation context. Participants described this use behaviour during tours as very 'isolating' [FGD-18] and 'annoying' [FGD-6, 12, 20], particularly when exercised by 'other' tour group members. Others went further to

accentuate how it could lead to conflicts with travel companions. Responses suggest these conflicts take various forms—from tacit tensions to open verbal arguments and strained relationships. As one noted:

I used to be the one who's very dependent on my mobile phone and he [pointing to husband] used to get mad at me. A lot of times, he would tell me 'Can you stop it? Can you just stop it? We are trying to have dinner—can you?' You are not there: you are on your mobile. You give it your attention ... [IDI-8].

Some participants tend to highlight on the missed opportunity to enhance kinship relationships. For instance, one traveller related this concern to couples on 'honeymoon':

The reason for honeymoon is for couples to get to know each other...but now what I notice with some of my friends and my family members when they went for honeymoon ... most of the time, they will be taking pictures with their phone. They will even forget the people [who are] with them and focus more on what they want to get especially the use of Snapchat that has become really important. Especially—now that I have it—I noticed how much I really feel am obliged to use it during travel. ... The only thing is that when you get less engaged [with your smartphone], you are able to see the people around you, contact more, you will be able to understand how they are feeling right now, what they are experiencing, what do they want to experience during the travel ... so when you have your phone or other communication devices, it takes away the pleasure of having company. [IDI-2].

In some cases, these injurious effects only became apparent to study participants after taking time to reflect on the questions and re-evaluate their travel experiences. For instance, one respondent [IDI-10] remarked after the interview session, 'Thinking about it again [i.e.,

smartphone use habits during travel vacation], I am beginning to feel guilty'. Another [IDI-12] noted, 'I now realize why my husband has been getting angry with me about this!'

Essentially, findings highlight a general recognition that trade-offs occur as tourists juggle their attention back and forth from the sights and sounds on the tourist trail to their MMDs. Many of the issues participants raised pivoted on *attention* and *awareness*, which can be related to the concept of *mindfulness*. Defined as a receptive attention to and awareness of present events and experience (Brown & Ryan, 2003), the concept of mindfulness has long been associated with the earliest forms of tourism when people travelled to hot springs, religious sites, and natural sceneries of outstanding beauty. The question that plausibly emerges is, to what extent could a tourist give *receptive attention* to and be *fully aware* of ongoing events and experiences on the tourist trail (i.e., sights, sounds, people, etc.) while concurrently engaged with information processing on mobile media devices?

Fig. 1 represents an effort to frame these issues graphically. In a nutshell, how tourists engage with MMDs in leisure vacations contexts (4.1) appears to lead to various forms of distractions and holds inherent implications for attention and awareness in the vacation milieu (4.2 a–e). These distractions have possible repercussions for (4.2 i) the quality and scope of the tourist's consumption of sights and sounds, (4.2 ii) the tourist's wellbeing and (4.2 iii) social interactions, as well as the experiences of others (the double ended arrow linking social interactions with others' experiences is a representation of how tourists' online/offline interactions could impact significant others/travel companions and vice versa).

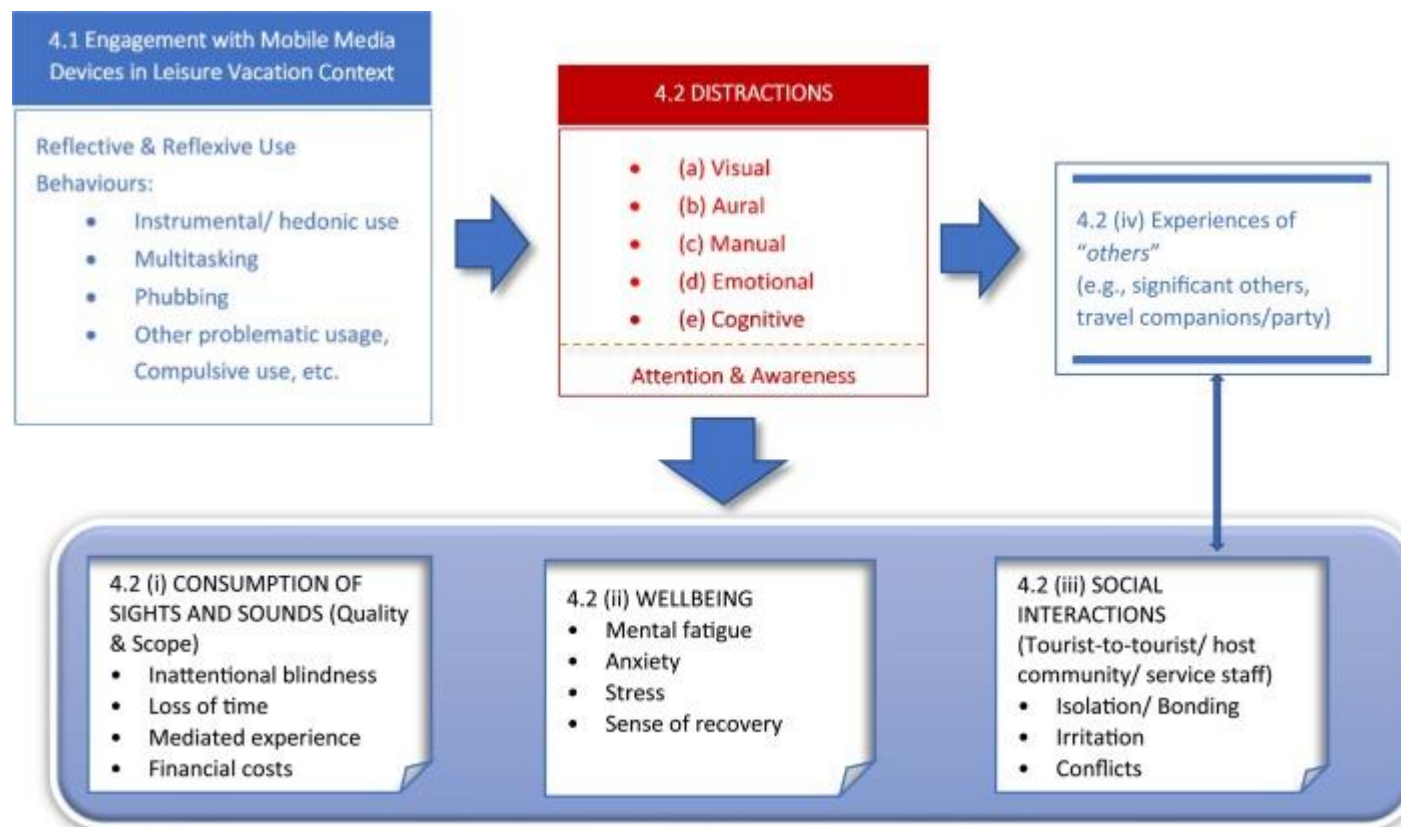


Fig. 1. Relating the problematic use of MMDs to leisure vacation outcomes.

5. Conclusion and implications

The study sought to bring to light some issues deemed important from both theoretical and practical perspectives. Digital technology has indeed altered the way tourists experience destinations; hence, inquiry into these experiences are opportune and essential. Yet, despite the immense popularity of MMDs among contemporary tourists, the deleterious effect of mobile distraction on the touristic experience is still largely overlooked by the tourism research community. Insights from this study could help stimulate additional research on the problematic usage of mobile technologies in the holiday context.

[Urry and Larsen \(2011\)](#) describe the tourist gaze as a ‘*performance* that orders, shapes, and classifies, rather than reflects the world’ [emphasis added] (p. 2). Both experimental literature

and research on everyday multitasking offer enormous evidence in support of the role of multitasking in diminishing 'performance'. In holiday contexts, this study suggests tourists may be generally aware of the potential of MMDs in lessening experiences on various dimensions through visual, aural, manual, emotive, and cognitive distractions. However, it appears this knowledge may not necessarily translate to appropriate use of mobile technologies during leisure vacation, suggesting that understanding the nature of this behaviour in the holiday environment is much more complex. Nonetheless, others are becoming increasingly concerned, giving rise to new forms of holidays such as 'digital detox' vacations (e.g., Digital Detox LLC, 2014; Time to Log Off, 2017).

Technology enthusiasts have regularly characterised laggards and non-adopters as technology resisters and technophobes (Brosnan, 1998; McClure, 2017) or naive opponents of technology. This tendency is arguably condescending in the leisure vacation context. This research suggests that, on the contrary, the incredulous predilection of some tourists to ignore, refuse, or delay the use of mobile technology in tourism-related contexts—though may seem countercultural—is perhaps justifiably prudent. Findings suggest that tourists are variably cognizant of the implications mobile technology has for the quality and scope of tourism consumptive experiences (sights and sounds), wellbeing and social interactions as well as others' experiences. Some scholars have cautioned that certain categories of travellers could possibly be alienated by tourist facilities which cater to their mobile networks (Burns & O'Regan, 2008; Paris, 2012). Evidently, thoughtless adoption of the latest technology without questioning how it impacts our goals and lives is misplaced.

It is imperative to highlight that since user behaviour is often reflexive, it is possible for mobile distraction to cause tourists' dissatisfaction with the travel experience without the realisation that the displeasure stems from phone use habits. This implies the need for tour

operators and destination service providers to constantly seek to understand the dominant motives of their tourist market segments and re-evaluate the use of technology in augmenting the touristic experience to ensure that the technology in itself does not become a distraction. Some have argued that to stay connected or not should be the decision of tourists and not obligatory (Kirillova & Wang, 2016); nonetheless, it is imperative for service providers to consider practical ways they could guide (and/or educate) tourists on the appropriate use of available technologies, as is done with other critical concerns of our time such as tourism ethics and eco-friendly practices.

Findings dispute aspects of the widely accepted view on technology usage in tourism contexts. Both research and practice have advanced on the fundamental premise that technology adoption is incredibly crucial to augmenting tourist experiences (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Burton-Jones & Grange, 2013; Law, Leung, & Buhalis, 2009). Giving the sensitivity of study participants to the deleterious effects on their tourist experiences, this assumption seems exaggerated and perhaps inaccurate. In the general IT literature, the findings of this study add to a limited but a growing number of studies (e.g., Roberts & David, 2016; Soror et al., 2015; Ugur & Koc, 2015) that serve to mitigate the positivity bias (i.e., the notion that modern technology is invariably advantageous; Mick & Fournier, 1998) that is often displayed in the technology research stream.

Though this study makes valuable contributions toward our understanding of the problematic use of MMDs in the tourism literature, it has its limitations and opens additional avenues for future research. The most obvious consideration is that the study reported here employed a qualitative approach to data collection and analysis. Its objectives were limited to identifying and obtaining insight into tourists' continual engagement with MMDs in the leisure vacation context and their awareness of the implications for their touristic experience. Given the

limitations of this approach, findings should be interpreted carefully. Nonetheless, insights drawn can serve as a valuable foundation for future research in this field. Future research (possibly using a different epistemological lens or methodological approach) is needed to examine these issues more thoroughly and to further explore how extrapolations drawn from the current study could be generalised.

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Appendix A. Background of study participants

#	Pseudonym	Age	Gender	Country	Family status	Profession	Technique
1	IDI-1	57	Female	Taiwan	Single	Researcher	In-depth Interview
2	IDI-2	22	Female	UAE	Single	Student	In-depth Interview
3	IDI-3	21	Female	UAE	Single	Student	In-depth Interview
4	IDI-4	40	Male	Portugal	Married	Archaeologist	In-depth Interview
5	IDI-5	44	Female	USA	Divorced, 2 children	Teacher	In-depth Interview
6	IDI-6	44	Female	USA	Separated, 3 children	Teacher	In-depth Interview
7	IDI-7	35	Female	USA	Single	Teacher	In-depth Interview
8	IDI-8	35	Female	Portugal	Married, 1 child	IT Marketer	In-depth Interview
9	IDI-9	55	Female	USA	Married, 4 children	Teacher	In-depth Interview
10	IDI-10	36	Female	USA	Married, 1 child	Teacher	In-depth Interview

#	Pseudonym	Age	Gender	Country	Family status	Profession	Technique
11	IDI-11	38	Female	Kenya	Married	PRO	In-depth Interview
12	IDI-12	31	Female	Canada	Married	Teacher	In-depth Interview
13	IDI-13	45	Female	South Africa	Divorced, 2 children	Teacher	In-depth Interview
14	IDI-14	40	Male	Kenya	Married, 2 children	Geographer	In-depth Interview
15	IDI-15	39	Female	Uganda	Married, 2 children	Housewife	In-depth Interview
16	IDI-16	51	Male	USA	Divorced	Teacher	In-depth Interview
17	IDI-17	36	Male	India	Married, 1 child	Medical R.	In-depth Interview
18	IDI-18	28	Male	USA	Married	Teacher	In-depth Interview
19	IDI-19	24	Female	USA	Married	T. Support	In-depth Interview
20	IDI-20	25	Female	USA	Married	Consultant	In-depth Interview
21	IDI-21	26	Male	USA	Married	Unemployed	In-depth Interview
22	IDI-22	51	Male	Australia	Married, 4 kids	Professor	In-depth Interview
23	FGD-1	19	Male	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
24	FGD-2	18	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
25	FGD-3	20	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
26	FGD-4	21	Male	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
27	FGD-5	19	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
28	FGD-6	20	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
29	FGD-7	19	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
30	FGD-8	21	Male	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
31	FGD-9	21	Male	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
32	FGD-10	21	Female	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
33	FGD-11	20	Female	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
34	FGD-12	21	Female	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
35	FGD-13	21	Female	USA	Single	Volunteer	Focus group
36	FGD-14	20	Male	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
37	FGD-15	19	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
38	FGD-16	20	Male	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
39	FGD-17	18	Male	USA	Single	Student	Focus group
40	FGD-18	20	Female	USA	Single	Student	Focus group

#	Pseudonym	Age	Gender	Country	Family status	Profession	Technique
41	FGD-19	21	Female	USA	Single	Unemployed	Focus group
42	FGD-20	21	Female	USA	Single	Unemployed	Focus group

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